

Meal Planning and Diet Templates

Balanced Meal Structure

A simple balanced meal can include:

1. a protein source;
2. a carbohydrate source;
3. vegetables or fruit;
4. a suitable fat source;
5. fluid.

Examples include:

- dal + rice + vegetables + curd;
- chicken + roti + vegetables;
- tofu + rice + mixed vegetables;
- eggs + whole-grain toast + fruit;
- paneer + roti + salad.

Exact proportions depend on:

- calorie needs;
- training demands;
- appetite;
- goals;
- food preferences.

Protein Sources

Vegetarian

- paneer;
- milk;
- curd;
- eggs if included;
- tofu;
- tempeh;
- soy chunks;
- lentils;
- chickpeas;
- kidney beans;

- peas;
- nuts;
- seeds.

Non-Vegetarian

- eggs;
- chicken;
- fish;
- lean meat;
- dairy foods.

Vegan

- tofu;
- tempeh;
- soy chunks;
- lentils;
- chickpeas;
- beans;
- peas;
- seitan;
- soy milk;
- plant protein powders.

Carbohydrate Sources

Useful options include:

- rice;
- roti;
- oats;
- potatoes;
- sweet potatoes;
- whole-grain bread;
- millet;
- fruits;
- beans;
- lentils.

Fat Sources

Useful options include:

- nuts;
- seeds;
- peanut butter;
- olive oil;
- mustard oil;
- avocado;
- fatty fish.

Muscle-Gain Template

Breakfast

- oats;
- milk or soy milk;
- banana;
- nuts or peanut butter;
- protein source.

Lunch

- rice or roti;
- dal;
- paneer, tofu, chicken, fish or eggs;
- vegetables;
- curd if included.

Pre-Workout

- fruit;
- yogurt, milk or another light protein source.

Post-Workout

- normal protein-containing meal;
- protein shake if convenient.

Dinner

- rice or roti;
- protein source;
- vegetables.

Additional Calories if Needed

- nuts;

- seeds;
- peanut butter;
- milk;
- extra grains;
- homemade high-calorie shake.

Fat-Loss Template

Breakfast

- protein source;
- oats, whole-grain food or vegetable poha;
- fruit.

Lunch

- moderate grain portion;
- protein source;
- dal if desired;
- large vegetable serving.

Snack

- fruit;
- curd or yogurt;
- roasted chickpeas or another protein-rich snack.

Dinner

- protein source;
- vegetables;
- moderate carbohydrate portion.

The calorie deficit across the overall diet is more important than any one specific meal.

Maintenance Template

A maintenance diet can follow the same basic structure:

- protein at major meals;
- fruit and vegetables daily;
- whole grains or other carbohydrate sources;
- appropriate dietary fats;
- flexible inclusion of enjoyable foods.

Portions can be adjusted so average energy intake approximately matches energy expenditure.

Eating Outside the Home

Restaurant meals can fit into a balanced diet.

Useful strategies include:

- prioritizing a protein source;
- including vegetables when available;
- choosing portions suitable for the goal;
- remembering that oils, sauces and dressings can add substantial calories;
- returning to normal eating at the next meal rather than compensating with extreme restriction.

Flexible Dieting

Healthy eating does not require permanently classifying foods as "clean" or "dirty."

A practical pattern is to:

- obtain most nutrition from nutrient-dense foods;
- meet protein needs;
- consume sufficient fibre;
- include fruits and vegetables;
- maintain calories appropriate for the goal;
- allow reasonable flexibility.

The overall dietary pattern matters more than one isolated meal.